



Beyond the snapshot: Rethinking crisis communication theories in dynamic crisis situations

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ABSTRACT

Traditional theories of crisis communication are often interpreted in ways that assume responsibility for a crisis is static. In such cases, response strategies are used as a "snapshot" to assess attributed crisis responsibilities under presumed static circumstances, which then define the most appropriate response strategies. This study challenges that notion, arguing that effective crisis responses must actively anticipate and adapt to evolving dynamics in ongoing crises. It explores the dynamics of assigned crisis responsibility through two key dimensions. First, the study addresses the dynamics that occur when perceptions of the cause of a crisis shift as new information becomes available. Second, it delves into the concept of shared responsibility, illustrating that accountability and assigned responsibility for a crisis may be distributed among various stakeholders as the crisis unfolds. Interactions among these stakeholders can change the dynamics by influencing perceived crisis responsibility. The study concludes that understanding these dynamics is crucial for effective crisis management, as they significantly impact stakeholder relations, public perception, and the choice of subsequent intervention strategies.

1. Introduction

Within the domain of crisis communication, the Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT) is a well-known framework developed by Coombs (1995, 2007b). The theory has been regarded as one of the dominant theories in crisis communication research (Avery et al., 2010). The SCCT asserts that crises are negative events that prompt individuals to attribute responsibility for the crisis to the organization implicated in it. According to Coombs (2017, p.22), the degree to which stakeholders attribute responsibility for the crisis to the organization in crisis, is the pivotal variable in SCCT. Similarly, Benoit (1997) uses the responsibility for an action considered offensive as the starting point for determining the appropriate crisis response strategy in his Image Restoration Theory (IRT). Similar to Coombs (1995) approach, Benoit (1997) uses the concept of perception. The effectiveness of a crisis response strategy depends not only on the actual facts of the situation but also on how those facts are perceived by the public.

The impact of perception on crisis communication has been well documented in prior research, but tends to have a short-term focus. As Capizzo et al. (2024) claim, much public relations scholarship has been overly focused on short-term responses and implications. Since crises

can cast long shadows ('t Hart and Boin, 2001), changing perceptions during the crisis or post-crisis phase may require adopting crisis response strategies. Yet, crisis communication theories such as IRT and SCCT typically offer a snapshot as the crisis unfolds, so to speak, of stakeholder perceptions at the onset of the crisis. The image captured in the snapshot then helps the organization determine the most appropriate crisis response strategy, based on its own perception of the crisis at hand and the interpretations of the stakeholders. Theories may anticipate the long-term impact of chosen crisis response strategies, but they rarely account for shifting perspectives as a crisis unfolds. Similarly, the widely adopted theory of *Discourse of Renewal* (Seeger et al., 2005) primarily focuses on the aftermath of crises and how public discourse can help move an organization through recovery and revitalization (Sellnow et al., 2022, p. 127). How to anticipate and respond to changing perceptions during an ongoing crisis is scarcely addressed in the crisis communication literature. This raises important questions about the adaptability of existing crisis communication strategies and whether they sufficiently reflect the dynamic nature of stakeholder perceptions. If perceptions evolve over time while the crisis itself is ongoing, then crisis response strategies must evolve as well—yet current theoretical frameworks offer limited guidance on how to navigate this

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ongoing process.

2. Literature review

Within crisis communication scholarship, a recent bibliographic analysis by Kuipers et al. (2023) identified Coombs' Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT; Coombs, 2007b) and Benoit's Image Repair Theory (IRT; Benoit, 1997) as the most frequently cited frameworks. Both theories focus on the attribution of responsibility to the organization or individual experiencing the crisis. In each, the recommended response strategies are contingent upon the degree of responsibility attributed, given the specific crisis context (Kuipers et al., 2023). A notable trend in the field is the increasing prevalence of SCCT in academic studies, accompanied by a decline in research grounded in IRT (Page et al., 2023).

Focusing on SCCT, the "situational" component of the theory refers to the context-specific factors that influence how an organization should respond to a crisis. The nature of a crisis—particularly its type, the organization's history with similar events, and its prior reputation—shapes how stakeholders interpret the situation and judge the organization (Coombs, 2007b). Once these situational factors are assessed, the level of reputational threat can be determined. This assessment subsequently guides the selection of an appropriate crisis response strategy (e.g., denial, apology, compensation) aimed at protecting or restoring the organization's reputation (Coombs, 2007b).

From this perspective, the appropriateness of a crisis response is not fixed but depends on context-specific variables that shape stakeholder expectations. For example, organizations with different reputational histories or levels of crisis experience may require distinct response strategies, even when facing similar crises. Despite this inherent contextual sensitivity, SCCT is often interpreted in a prescriptive manner, offering a seemingly clear roadmap for how to respond once the threat level is established. As Niu and Ma (2023) observe, most researchers apply SCCT in a straightforward fashion—often through case studies and content analysis—without critically testing its causal assumptions. An example is the meta-study by Arendt et al. (2017), which found that corrective action tends to be the most effective strategy across 110 peer-reviewed articles, particularly when combined with efforts to reduce offensiveness.

This narrow application tends to overlook the potential dynamics triggered by the crisis response itself. In practice, crises frequently evolve over time; during this process, organizational reputations may shift, and stakeholders' perceptions of causality can change as new evidence or narratives emerge (McDonald et al., 2010; Ndone & Kyriakopoulos, 2024). Van der Meer et al. (2017) highlight this non-static nature of crises and identify a significant research gap in understanding how these evolving dynamics unfold. According to their (Van der Meer et al., 2017) findings, stakeholders are not passive observers; they can reshape crisis narratives by re-assigning responsibility, mobilizing boycotts, or initiating legal action—thereby altering the organization's relationship with them as the crisis progresses.

Although Coombs (2007a) emphasizes the importance of continuous media monitoring and stakeholder analysis during a crisis, the practical application of the SCCT framework does not fully account for the dynamic and iterative nature of crises. In his later work, however, Coombs (2018) acknowledges the evolving aspects of crises, particularly by positioning rhetoric as the foundation of crisis communication scholarship. Drawing on the work of Heath (2009), Coombs suggests that crises are inherently dialogic—characterized by a continuous interplay of competing voices and interpretations. This implies that, throughout a crisis, there is ongoing interaction between the organization or individual and external stakeholders, during which perceptions and attributions of responsibility may shift over time. While crisis managers must consider whether to prioritize short-term gains or long-term recovery in their communication efforts (Coombs, 2015), they must also remain attentive to the evolving nature of the crisis, continuously reassessing

whether their chosen strategy aligns with shifting stakeholder perceptions and situational developments.

When the rhetorical foundation is treated as a core element, it becomes evident that crises are not discrete, static events but dynamic rhetorical constructs that evolve through ongoing interpretation and response—sometimes within, and sometimes beyond, the control of the organization under scrutiny. In such contexts, organizations must engage in real-time efforts to shape and reshape public understanding of the crisis through strategic communication. While Van der Meer et al. (2017) emphasize the interaction between the organization or individual in crisis and its stakeholders, this interaction should be regarded as a consequence of change, rather than its source. In order to anticipate these changes, it is important for crisis communication professionals to understand where potential shifts in perceptions and attributions may originate. Echoing Kim (2022), we argue that crisis managers should foster continuous interaction with publics through timely, context-specific communication—grounded in an understanding of the origins of shifting perceptions and attributions.

To contribute to this perspective, this article pursues two key objectives: (1) to define and enhance our understanding of the origins of potentially changing attributions of responsibility during the crisis phase or post-crisis phase, and (2) to discuss communication recommendations to incorporate anticipation for such situations.

3. Origins of shifts in perceptions

From the fundamental principle that a crisis stems from a cause, which then generates perceptions and assigns responsibility for that cause, two key elements emerge. The first element that can create dynamics in perceptions as the crisis unfolds, is a changing perspective on the cause of a crisis. In a study examining the influence of incident evaluations on crisis communication, Jong (2019) demonstrates that when new causes are uncovered through an evaluation, altering the understanding of the crisis's origins, established perceptions are subsequently shifted. For example, in a train accident in Hoboken, the speed of the train was initially identified as the cause until it was later discovered that the driver's insomnia had also played a significant role (Jong, 2019). In such contexts, these new or additional causes are the variables that were referred to by Van der Meer et al. (2017), that can suddenly provide a new perspective on the situation and the employers responsibility, as it shifts from a technical cause to a more human error.

A second origin of potential dynamics lies in the number of stakeholders involved. In this context, a distinction can be made between external stakeholders—such as customers, the media, or regulators—who observe or respond to the crisis from outside the operational environment, and crisis partners, who are actively involved in the same crisis setting alongside the organization. The term *crisis partners* is used here to clearly indicate those actors who, to varying degrees, share responsibilities, risks, and decision-making pressures during the crisis. Examples include pilots or port authorities in a maritime incident or, in the case of an airline crash, the airline, airport authorities, air traffic control towers, and regulatory agencies such as the Federal Aviation Administration (FAA). Recognizing this distinction is essential for understanding the dynamics of crisis communication and coordination in complex, multi-actor environments.

When a company is involved in a crisis on its own, it bears full responsibility for the cause, which simplifies the process of delivering a unified message, even when responsibilities are distributed across different parts of the organization. But when multiple actors are involved in a crisis situation collectively, it is likely that no one bears full responsibility for the crisis as a whole. According to Zhang and Nekmat (2023), current crisis communication literature has primarily focused on how a single organization strategically responds to crises, leaving the dynamic, multi-actor nature of crisis situations relatively underexplored. However, in many real-world crises, organizations under pressure do not act in isolation. In such situations, it becomes difficult to

predict how stakeholders will assign blame or responsibility among the various crisis partners involved—especially when the extent of each actor's involvement is uncertain and uneven.

When a shared responsibility is assigned to all crisis partners, some may be held accountable for minor contributing factors, while others may have played a significant and more dominant role in causing the crisis. As the number of stakeholders in a crisis increases, the pressure to point at other parties involved might change the perceptions of ones' relative responsibility, laying the ground for blame games (Resodihardjo, 2020). Pille and Prins (2018) describe a so-called Project X party, which occurred in September 2012 after a teenage girl's birthday party invitation went viral on social media. Although the girl removed her invitation from Facebook, others began organizing a party in her name, using fake names or anonymity online. This Project X party attracted thousands of uninvited guests, leading to riots, vandalism, and clashes with the police, resulting in substantial property damage and multiple arrests. In public opinion, the responsibility for the cause of the crisis shifted away from the birthday girl to the mayor, who was blamed for a lack of preparation, as well as to the police force and the public prosecutor (Pille & Prins, 2018). Additionally, Facebook was criticized by public and authorities for not intervening and moderating online messages to prevent the riots. Especially when one actor starts to blame other crisis partners for inadequate preparation, the assigned responsibilities can shift significantly, a process that is intrinsic to many of the politically oriented accountability phases in the aftermath of crises (Resodihardjo, 2020).

This article is exploratory in nature, aiming to challenge the current robustness of existing crisis communication theories and present additions to highlight the dynamic elements into these theories. We introduce a heuristic framework (Fig. 1) consisting of the two origins of changes in perceptions proposed above. One dimension in Fig. 1 is the distinction between cases with a single actor versus those crises where multiple crisis partners are involved. The other dimension in Fig. 1 distinguishes between crises with a clear, single cause versus those crises with multiple causes, which consist of large or small contributing factors.

Before discussing the implications of these four distinct types of dynamics for selecting the appropriate crisis response strategy, the four quadrants will be examined below. The components of Fig. 1. are clarified through the use of empirical examples for illustrative purposes.

4. Single actor, single cause: shifting perceptions through a reinterpretation of the cause

On October 29, 2018, Lion Air flight 610, departing from Jakarta for Pangkal Pinang in Indonesia, tragically crashed into the Java Sea just 13 minutes after takeoff, resulting in the loss of all 189 passengers and crew. A mere five months later, on March 10, 2019, Ethiopian Airlines flight 302, en route to Nairobi, Kenya, crashed just six minutes after takeoff from Addis Ababa, Ethiopia, claiming the lives of all 157

individuals on board. At both crashes, a brand new Boeing 737-Max 8 was involved. Whereas the first crash with Boeing's new aircraft was initially viewed by most stakeholders as a fatal accident, the second crash shed new light on the matter (Jong & Broekman, 2021). The second crash made it clear that there was a structural design error on Boeing's part here, which retroactively also proved to be the cause of the first crash. The case study demonstrates that even the cause of a crisis is never entirely definitive, as new developments can provide fresh insights into the situation. Here, Boeing was no longer seen as a manufacturer that had fallen victim to a fatal accident, but as one that had taken a risk with the safety of its flagship product due to numerous factors. The first crash was no longer regarded as accidental but one that could have been prevented (Jong & Broekman, 2021). This change in perception and attribution was based on the publicly available knowledge that was released after of the second crash. This reinterpretation intensified the threat to Boeing's reputation and raised doubts about the appropriateness of the initial response.

The initial response by Boeing after the Lion Air crash might have been appropriate at the time. Boeing acknowledged the crash and stated that the *"Boeing Company is deeply saddened by the loss of Lion Air Flight 610. We extend our heartfelt condolences and sympathies to the families and loved ones of those onboard. Safety is a core value for everyone at Boeing and the safety of our airplanes, our customers' passengers and their crews is always our top priority"* (Boeing, 2018a). However, the emphasis on safety became rather inappropriate, when the investigation into the second crash showed that safety of the airplanes was not top priority and countries and airlines around the world began to ground the Boeing 737 Max. Rather than managing a crisis where it was the victim of an unavoidable disaster, Boeing found itself embroiled in a series of crises that stemmed from its own responsibility, as the crashes could have been prevented in the first place. The new perspective on the initial cause of the crash introduced dynamics that made the original statement unfitting.

In another example, Strandberg and Vigsø (2016) discuss a case study where an employee stole money at a Swedish municipality. As such, the case describes a single cause and actor. Similar to Martinko et al. (2009) observations that an organization in crisis may have a distorted view of existing perceptions, Strandberg and Vigsø (2016) describe how management viewed the crisis as unrelated to cultural issues, while employees believed responsibility was shared. Employees saw the blame placed on their former colleague as an attempt to avoid organizational accountability for its responsibility in the crisis. As such, the colleagues shed new light on the cause, highlighting circumstances that were relevant to them but had been ignored by the municipality they worked for.

5. Single actor, multiple causes: shifting perceptions through reinterpretation of underlying factors

When a tech company experiences a data breach, the severity of assigned responsibility may increase if evaluation studies reveal that the company cannot fully shift the blame to hackers. For example, this may occur if it is found that the company was using outdated security software and provided insufficient employee training, thereby making it an easier target for hackers. When the cyber-attack was made possible by a lack of internal compliance, the perception shifts from a company that fell victim to a cyber-attack to a company that is at least partly responsible for giving cyber criminals the opportunity to attack, as it failed to implement update procedures and provide adequate training. Even though the hackers were still responsible for the data breach, the contributing factors broaden the scope and heighten the responsibility assigned to the company involved. Compared to the Boeing case, the cause itself is not questioned as the hackers are the main cause in either scenario. It is, however, the contributing factors that raise the assigned responsibility of the company involved as the crisis unfolds.

Sheppard and Young (2023) discuss a similar situation in their

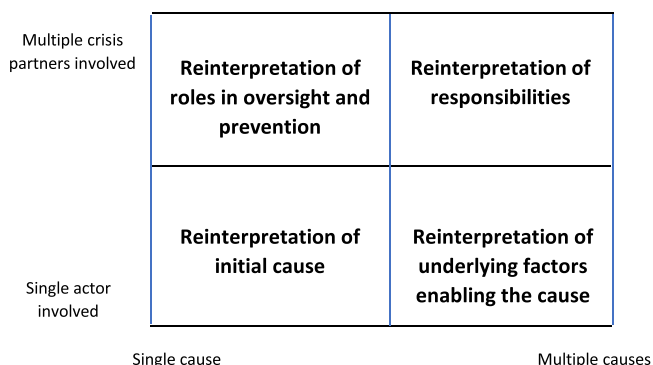


Fig. 1. Dynamics in the origins of crises as basis for crisis response.

reflection on the *Deepwater Horizon* oil rig explosion in 2010. They identify a range of contributing factors that together led to the disaster, which resulted in 11 fatalities and long-term environmental damage along the Gulf Coast. At the individual level, cognitive biases influenced poor decision-making, while at the organizational level, limited information processing, restricted communication, and tightened control discouraged the adoption of safer or alternative strategies. These conditions reinforced habitual responses, producing rigid behavior that unintentionally intensified the crisis. Rather than a single cause, the incident was the result of a chain of interrelated factors—each playing a role in shaping the event and the subsequent attribution of blame directed toward British Petroleum (BP), the company overseeing the project.

6. Multiple actors, single cause: shifting perceptions through a reinterpretation of responsibilities

Similar to the quadrant explained above, multiple actors can be involved in a crisis with varying levels of responsibility. In their article, [Resodihardjo et al. \(2018\)](#) describe an open-air monster truck show that goes terribly wrong. During the show, the monster truck drives into the audience, resulting in three fatalities. In terms of crisis response, one might expect that all fingers would point toward the driver of the monster truck as the one to blame for the fatal incident, requiring him to provide a crisis response appropriate to the circumstances. However, the aftermath reveals a much more nuanced version of what happened at the accident. After a year-long investigation, it is found that the responsibility does not lie solely with the driver of the monster truck. Even though the driver should have been more careful in his show, the investigation also points to the local authorities and the event organizer, who should have been more critical about the permit and the requirements surrounding the show. In retrospect, the investigation committee draws the conclusion that the distance between the event and the public was too short, and there were no substantial barriers to stop the monster truck. As such committees often have a high level of authority and a strong reputation, their analysis can act as a game-changer when it comes to assigning responsibilities ([Broekema et al., 2025](#)). Sometimes, this changes the assigned responsibility of the organizing crisis partners significantly. Here, a greater emphasis is placed on the municipality which was initially perceived as less accountable. This dynamic illustrates how perceptions of responsibility can shift over time, particularly in complex crisis scenarios involving multiple parties. However, the short distance could also have signaled to the driver not to proceed with the show, meaning he still bears considerable responsibility according to the committee.

Even though the cause of the crisis does not change in retrospect, the assigned responsibility changes, as parties should and could have used their influence and authorities to minimize the chances of this crisis occurring. This can become rather dynamic in the aftermath of crises, as [Jin et al. \(2020\)](#) describe. They ([Jin et al., 2020](#)) note that, from the public's perspective, information regarding crisis responsibility often seems conflicting or unclear, as multiple sources may report on the incident, use media channels and other sources to blame each other for the root-cause of the crisis.

7. Multiple actors, multiple causes: shifting perceptions through a redistribution of shared responsibilities

Real-life crisis situations often involve multiple parties, both companies and public entities, that share their responsibility even under normal circumstances. Joint responsibility can be understood as a collection of individual responsibilities held by crisis partners who, together, contribute to the functioning of a shared system. For example, when the container ship *Ever Given* became stuck in the Suez Canal on March 23, 2021, various crisis partners had roles in the crisis. These included shipowners Higaki Sangyo Kaisha Ltd and Luster Maritime S.

A., the operator Bernhard Schulte Ship Management, bridge team members, the captain, maritime pilots, and the Suez Canal Authority ([Panama Maritime Authority, 2021](#)) among others. The ship was ultimately refloated and freed on March 29, 2021, after six days of intense efforts involving dredging and the use of tugboats. In addition to the Suez Canal Authority, several other parties were involved in the resolution, such as salvage companies (e.g., Boskalis), the Egyptian government, insurance companies, and maritime and legal experts. The final report concluded that multiple parties failed to anticipate adverse weather conditions, which contributed to the crisis. Additionally, language barriers between the maritime pilots and the onboard crew complicated the situation further.

In major crises, such a joint responsibility is the rule rather than the exception. All parties work together to make a system function, whether it's guiding a ship through the Suez Canal or running a train from North Dakota to Saint John, Canada, as was the case with the train that derailed in Lac-Mégantic in 2013. The Transportation Safety Board of Canada ([TSBC, 2014](#)) pinpointed 18 separate contributing factors to the incident. These factors were related to responsibilities of multiple stakeholders, from the railway company, the regulatory body to the train driver. The mishap wasn't the result of a single individual, action, or entity but emerged from a web of interconnected factors. The disaster, which resulted in 47 fatalities, was caused by a complex combination of factors involving these parties, including railway operations, regulatory oversight, emergency response, and broader industry practices.

The responsible actor for each contributing cause is typically identified shortly after a crisis. However, it remains unclear which crisis partner played the decisive role, as the impact of contributing factors can range from minor to major. When the final verdict is presented in an investigation report, the emphasis on one party's responsibility may shift considerably in relation to other actors involved. This suggests that responsibility can shift among collaborating entities after an incident. An investigation board or media report may later clarify and reflect on each party's role in causing the disaster. As with the *Ever Given* incident, assigning blame to other parties early on, when there is still a possibility that the final report may significantly implicate your own actions, may not be the wisest course of action.

The parties involved are not necessarily bound to those who had a stake in the cause of the crises, but can even be enlarged to parties who are involved in solving the crisis. On February 3, 2023, a train transporting hazardous chemicals went off the tracks in the community of East Palestine, USA. The derailment led to a blaze that enveloped the community of East Palestine in a smoky haze ([Hauser, 2023](#)). To mitigate the risk of a blast, officials established an evacuation perimeter and executed a managed discharge of poisonous gases to stabilize the combustible materials within several train compartments ([Hauser, 2023](#)). While Norfolk Southern, the rail company, was the primary responsible party for the cause of the crisis, local and federal authorities had their stake in the aftermath of the crisis. In an opinion letter to the New York Times, a former regional administrator of the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) blames the EPA ([Enck, 2023](#)) for its highly ineffective and negligent approach. It turns the focus away from Norfolk Southern to EPA, which is criticized for its failure to conduct timely and comprehensive testing for toxins, its lack of clear communication with affected residents, and its tendency to defer too much to state agencies with less experience and lax regulations, leaving the community at risk ([Enck, 2023](#)).

To the EPA, the initial cause of the train derailment didn't appear to be a topic for which they perceived themselves as responsible. However, when applying crisis response strategies to this catastrophe, it's important to recognize that responsibilities aren't confined only to the parties directly involved in causing the crisis. The example demonstrates that new stakeholders may acquire responsibilities focused primarily on resolving the crisis. While these stakeholders are perceived as part of the overall crisis narrative, their roles can be distinct from the crisis's initial cause. Therefore, all parties should anticipate on potentially attributed

responsibilities they might face later on in the crisis resolution. Simply not being responsible for the crisis's cause doesn't exempt anyone from the need to apply crisis response strategies effectively.

8. Discussion

Where Coombs (2017) states that the attributed responsibility for the crisis is the pivotal variable in SCCT, the examples above show that the interpretation of this responsibility can be rather dynamic, not static, in the course of a crisis. Knowing that, it carries a risk. For when an organization assumes that its choice of an appropriate crisis response strategy is in line with stakeholders' perceptions, it may come home from a rude awakening. After all, if the assessment of responsibility for the crisis starts to change due to internal or external factors, then the crisis response strategy no longer adequately matches the attribution of responsibilities. While it is widely recommended for an organization facing a crisis to respond promptly (Zhang & Nekmat, 2023; Coombs, 2007b), such a response should remain adaptable, allowing for adjustments as new details about the cause of the crisis emerge or as the distribution of responsibility among crisis partners evolves.

This change in perceptions as a result of a different perspective on the origins of a crisis can be a decisive factor for the credibility and long-term trust of the organization involved. However, there is no luxury of waiting for future developments before making a statement. Right after a crisis hits, stakeholders expect a prompt communication response from the organizations involved, whether they are corporate entities or public agencies. The timeliness and clarity of this response are crucial for effective crisis management. These statements not only offer the organization's viewpoint on its responsibility but also provide clear guidance to stakeholders on actions needed to minimize impact. Both public agencies and corporations are expected to clarify the situation, its implications, and the steps being taken to mitigate its effects and learn to prevent future incidents.

To incorporate the dynamic nature of changing perceptions in ongoing crises, anticipation on changes in causes and shared responsibilities is proposed. As discussed, the initial judgment on crisis responsibility can be viewed as a snapshot of the current situation. This assessment helps formulate a strategy that aligns with the attributed responsibility, facilitating smooth communication with key stakeholders about the organization's current stance. However, without acknowledging that future perceptions may change, a potential mismatch could loom on the horizon. Waiting until these changing perceptions on the attributed responsibility materialize, will be too late. As demonstrated in the United Airlines case study by Benoit (2018), merely taking multiple 'snapshots' in succession proved insufficient. Specifically, adjusting a crisis response strategy during the unfolding situation fails to prevent reputational damage in all cases, as the situation with CEO Munoz and United Airlines showed.

Thus, we need to look beyond the 'snapshot' and anticipate future developments if we want to be prepared for changing attributions of responsibility in the long run. As such, preparing for future changes in perception requires an additional step. Organizations must anticipate possible changes from the perspective of key stakeholders. For instance, one can assess the current point of view and perception of Stakeholder A and consider how this perception might worsen or improve over time. As a "what-if" communication scenario, the practitioner plans ahead to decide the best strategy if the most negative perception materializes. This implies that doors are left open in case the situation worsens rather than stabilizes. This suggested strategy can be illustrated by IKEA's handling of the Russia boycott following the Ukraine invasion in 2022. As IKEA operated in Russia, it faced pressure from consumers to exit the Russian market. The company's communication approach can be seen as a textbook example in anticipation. IKEA took a step-by-step approach, initially announcing on March 3, 2022, that it was "pausing operations in Russia and Belarus" (IKEA, 2022a). This statement enabled IKEA to buy time and left the door open for changing circumstances and

perceptions among stakeholders, stating that the situation was "extremely critical and fast-moving" (IKEA, 2022a). In a follow-up statement on June 15, 2022, IKEA announced that it was taking "the next step to scale down in Russia and Belarus" due to the ongoing crisis (IKEA, 2022b). The consistency between the two statements allowed for a smooth transition when the situation worsened. By deliberately using phrases like "the next step," the two statements became part of a unified and consistent narrative.

In contrast, Boeing's statement following the first crash in Indonesia indicated the company's confidence that it was not directly responsible for the crisis, assuring "that the 737 MAX is as safe as any airplane that has ever flown the skies" (Boeing, 2018a). Had Boeing left room for the possibility of a technical failure, the two statements would have been more coherent and the overall crisis response would be consistent. By failing to anticipate negative future perceptions, Boeing missed the opportunity to issue a statement acknowledging that a technical fault couldn't be ruled out, even if considered unlikely. Instead, Boeing's subsequent statement confirmed their original stance, declaring, "We are confident in the safety of the 737 MAX" (Boeing, 2018b), worsening the reputation of the company even further.

In light of the Project X party, anticipation could have offered an alternative valuable approach. When taken the riots as a snapshot, the mayor might have pointed to the youngsters behind the Project X initiative and those who started the riot in his peaceful town. This is a strategy that primarily builds on blame. However, anticipation on future perceptions and attributions of responsibility might have pointed him into a different direction. Even though the mayor would not be able to fully assess his and others' responsibilities on the evening of the riots, he could have been guided by the worst perception of his most important (political) stakeholders. In that case, the point of departure is that the mayor will be held fully responsible for not being able to prevent the riots. In his response, the mayor could have proactively assumed responsibility by acknowledging that he "felt responsible" (Jong, 2019), while leaving room for future reports that might suggest otherwise. Within an organizational context, feeling responsible is a flexible concept, allowing the degree of responsibility to be defined more precisely at a later stage. In contrast, being responsible is a binary concept—either you are or you are not—offering less room for changing perceptions over time.

9. Conclusion

Traditional crisis communication theories—both in practice and academic analysis—are often applied with the assumption that responsibility for a crisis remains relatively static. The attribution of responsibility is not as straightforward as these theories might suggest, given that circumstances can change and customers may change their expectations and attribution of responsibility. This paper does not critique existing theories such as IRT (Benoit, 1997) or SCCT (Coombs, 2007b), but instead focuses on how these theories are applied in practice—particularly the limited guidance they offer for responding to shifting perceptions during an ongoing crisis. Gaining insight into the dynamics of an ongoing crisis can help practitioners select more appropriate response strategies, anticipate developments, and maintain credibility throughout the crisis. The proposed framework in Fig. 1 is positioned as a practical tool to aid in selecting appropriate crisis responses, independent of any specific theoretical model. Therefore, this study proposes that the perception guiding the choice of a crisis response strategy should not be treated as a static 'snapshot'. Instead, it should anticipate future changes and consider how their initial responses will be perceived later on, whether the circumstances surrounding the crisis improve or worsen. By considering stakeholders' current and future perceptions, organizations can issue more appropriate public statements, thereby preserving their credibility and reputation throughout the crisis. To do this effectively, the appropriateness of crisis response strategies should always be assessed based on potential courses of

action. Only when an organization prepares its crisis communication strategy for deteriorating circumstances with varying attributions of responsibility do current crisis communication theories retain their value for crisis communication practitioners. In essence, existing crisis communication theories' value to both crisis communication scholars and practitioners can be optimized when it accommodates for evolving stakeholder perceptions and changing circumstances, thereby acting as a stabilizing component in a broader crisis management architecture. This involves proactive anticipation of potential future changes in public sentiment and changing perceptions, in order to be credible and consistent both in the immediate aftermath and in the longer run. To further explore the practical and theoretical value of this approach, future research could empirically test propositions derived from the proposed framework in Fig. 1. Based on the case studies presented, one testable proposition could be: *"When stakeholder attributions of crisis responsibility shift during an ongoing crisis due to new perspectives on its cause, organizations that anticipate and adapt their communication strategy accordingly will maintain higher levels of trust and credibility than those that do not."* Alternatively, to assess the robustness of the framework across complex crisis settings, another proposition might be: *"In crises involving multiple actors, organizations that proactively anticipate potential shifts in the attribution of blame over time will maintain higher levels of trust and credibility than those that do not."* Doing so helps to refine the guidance that crisis communication research can provide for communication practitioners in times of crisis.

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